

To avoid detection, he may use proxies or zombie machines so that his location can't be determined.

With the technology and tools available today, hacking has become easier. With the wrong intent, anyone can hack – right from a disgruntled employee to a jilted lover. The disgruntled employee may destroy files or read confidential documents and a jilted lover might reveal intimate details to public. Many high-profile hackers are in their 20s and 30s. However, many are simply teenagers who have access to publicly available hacking tools that can be downloaded easily online.

What do they want?

A hacker can have many reasons for doing what he does. Here's a list of what hackers are generally after:

- ▶ **Spam:** Most hackers are interested in getting their code onto personal computers so that they can be turned into spam machines. This way they can publicise useless products for which they get paid by the company. If you can hijack thousands of other computers to do the spam-sending, you retain your anonymity and have a spam network that's hard to shut down because each sending machine has to be blocked one at a time.
- ▶ **Corporate data:** Corporate networks are highly protected because they have very sensitive data. A breach in the security can compromise their ability to function. A hacker knows this and hacks into the system to extort or blackmail the company. He can also steal data and sell it in the black market.
- ▶ **Personal computers:** Your PC has a lot more important data than you think. Although personal computers are not prime targets for elite hackers, they still remain an attractive target for the script kiddies. Most often they look for your financial account details to rip you off your money. Some of them might just want to snoop around in your inbox. Others might want to take control of your laptop.
- ▶ **Mobile phones:** Mobile phones are usually hacked to make free calls while the victim is charged for them. However with the new smartphones, your phone can be targeted for your account details, your personal documents, photos etc.
- ▶ **Web servers:** Any web site is hosted on a web server. If the web server is compromised, the hacker can deface the web site to display information of the hacker's choice to the public.